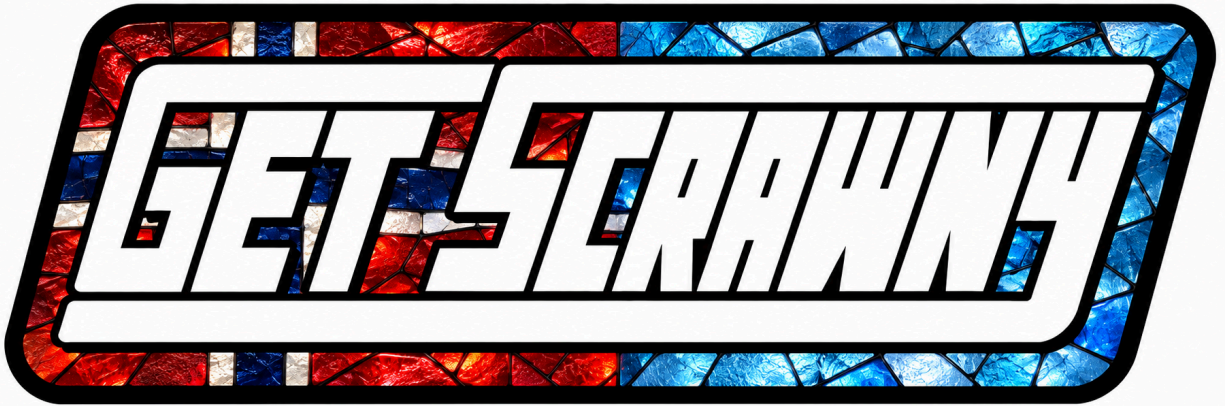




Erling Haaland

By: Scrawny Johnny



ERLING HAALAND was born in LEEDS, England, in 2000 while his father, Alf-Inge Haaland, was playing professional football there, but Erling grew up in the small Norwegian town of BRYNE. His mother, Gry Marita Braut, had competed in the HEPTATHLON (a seven-event track and field competition), while several relatives also became professional footballers. Haaland joined Bryne FK as a child, and youth coach Espen Undheim remembers that even then, “he loved scoring goals” and would get angry with himself when he missed a good chance. As a kid, Haaland and his friends practically lived on an indoor football pitch in town, playing whenever they were not at school, eating, or sleeping. By 15 years old, he was already playing senior (superior, ranked) football for Bryne against grown professionals. Long before the world knew the blond hair, meditation celebration, and the iconic number nine shirt, his COMPETITIVE (driven, determined) relationship with scoring was already there.

Let's spell: SENIOR RELATIVES COMPETITIVE MEDITATION

Haaland was born in what English city? LEEDS

What Norwegian town did Haaland grow up in? BRYNE

What seven-event sport had Haaland's mother competed in? HEPTATHLON

According to youth coach Espen Undheim, what did Haaland love scoring? GOALS

As a kid, Haaland and his friends practically lived on an _____ football pitch in town. INDOOR

Give me a synonym for senior mentioned in the passage. SUPERIOR, RANKED

We mentioned Haaland and friends practically living at an indoor pitch, playing whenever they weren't: (AT) SCHOOL, EATING, SLEEPING

Give me a synonym for competitive mentioned in the passage. DRIVEN, DETERMINED

How many goals does it take for a player to complete a hattrick? THREE

Norway is located on what continent? EUROPE

What is something you enjoyed as a kid that you could have done it for hours without getting bored?

Do you think growing up around professional sports would make it easier or harder to become an athlete yourself? Why?

If you were naturally talented at something but became angry every time you made a mistake, would that help your improvement or eventually work against you?



Haaland moved to Norwegian side, MOLDE, in 2017, where he developed under future Manchester United manager Ole Gunnar Solskjær, but 2019 was when things started to get ridiculous (absurd, outrageous). At the FIFA U-20 World Cup that summer, he scored nine goals in one match as Norway beat HONDURAS 12–0, setting a record for the most goals by one player in an 11-a-side FIFA tournament match. Norway still failed to advance (further, proceed), and Haaland’s reaction says a lot about him: after scoring nine, he said it annoyed him that he had missed another chance near the end. After transferring to Red Bull SALZBURG in AUSTRIA, his first Champions League appearance began with a goal inside two minutes and ended with a first-half hat trick against GENK. He kept scoring throughout the group stage, including at ANFIELD, Liverpool’s home stadium, and finished his six Champions League games for Salzburg with eight goals. At 19 years old, Haaland had gone from a promising (hopeful, encouraging) Norwegian striker to one of the most talked-about young players in European football.

Let’s spell: START CHANCE PROMISING TOURNAMENT

What Norwegian club did Haaland join in 2017? MOLDE

Haaland’s coach at Molde, Ole Gunnar Solskjær, went on to coach Manchester _____. UNITED

Which country did Norway defeat when Haaland scored nine goals in one match? HONDURAS

What famous stadium did we identify as Liverpool’s home field? ANFIELD

Haaland joined Austrian club, Red Bull _____. SALZBURG

Give me a synonym for advance mentioned in the passage. ABSURD, OUTRAGEOUS

Give me a synonym for ridiculous mentioned in the passage. FURTHER, PROCEED

Give me a synonym for promising mentioned in the passage. HOPEFUL, ENCOURAGING

We mentioned Manchester United, what color are they known to represent? RED

What Red Bull ingredient is known to give people energy? CAFFEINE

What is one reason a young athlete might choose to leave their home country to continue developing?

Haaland scored nine times and still thought about the one chance he missed. What does that tell you about his mentality?

Would you rather be remembered for one unbelievable performance or for being consistently great over many years? Why?



BORUSSIA DORTMUND signed Haaland in January 2020, and his first German league match made all the hype look REASONABLE (logical, rational). Dortmund were losing 3–1 to Augsburg when the 19-year-old came off the bench in the 56th minute; he scored with one of his first touches, completed a hat trick in about 20 minutes, and Dortmund came back to win 5–3. Watching Haaland can feel strange because his PHYSICAL (strong, powerful) size assumes a certain style of player while his movement gives you something completely different. At roughly six-foot-four, he could battle defenders physically, then suddenly ACCELERATE (speed up, quicken) behind them with the speed of a much smaller forward. He also did not need constant touches of the ball to affect a game; sometimes he seemed quiet for long stretches before appearing directly in front of goal at exactly the right moment. His Champions League scoring became absurdly fast too, reaching 20 goals in only 14 appearances, a mark nobody before him had reached that quickly.

Let's spell: NOBODY PHYSICAL SMALLER APPEARANCES

Which German club signed Haaland in 2020? BORUSSIA DORTMUND

Haaland's first German league match made all the hype look _____. REASONABLE

In Haaland's first German match, he came off the _____ in the 56th minute. BENCH

Haaland came into the game and scored a _____ in about 20 minutes. HAT TRICK

Haaland can suddenly _____ behind defenders with the speed of a much smaller forward. ACCELERATE

Give me a synonym for reasonable mentioned in the passage. LOGICAL, RATIONAL

Give me a synonym for physical mentioned in the passage. STRONG, POWERFUL

Give me a synonym for accelerate mentioned in the passage. SPEED UP, QUICKEN

What player's position is usually responsible for stopping an attacking striker? DEFENDER

What body part is primarily used to kick a soccer ball? FOOT

What makes somebody an icon instead of simply a very successful athlete?

What would be more difficult to defend: a player who is extremely fast, extremely strong, or extremely good at finding space? Why?

Haaland could appear quiet for long stretches and then suddenly score. Do you think that makes a player more frustrating to defend than someone who constantly has the ball?



MANCHESTER CITY provided Haaland's biggest test when he joined the club in 2022, the same team his father had once played for. There were questions (challenge, inquire) about how smoothly a direct, physical striker would fit into coach PEP GUARDIOLA's possession-heavy style and whether Premier League defenders would give him the same space he had found in Germany. Those questions did not last very long. Haaland scored 36 league goals in his first season, breaking the Premier League single-season record, while City won the Premier League, FA Cup, and Champions League to complete the TREBLE. The individual performances became just as unbelievable: three consecutive home league hat tricks, five goals against RB Leipzig in one Champions League match, and 52 goals across all competitions during his first year in England. What makes plenty of his goals especially frustrating for defenders is how predictable (expected, foreseeable) they can look, you know the cross is coming, the defender knows the cross is coming, and somehow Haaland still finds the space to reach it first.

Let's spell: POSSESSION CONSECUTIVE PREDICTABLE FRUSTRATING

What English club did Haaland join in 2022? MANCHESTER CITY

Haaland's _____ had previously played for Manchester City, who in his family? FATHER

Who was Manchester City's manager when Haaland arrived? PEP GUARDIOLA

Haaland scored 36 league goals in his first _____ in the Premier League. SEASON

Manchester City won three major competitions to complete the _____. TREBLE

Give me a synonym for questions mentioned in the passage. CHALLENGE, INQUIRE

Name one of the three competitions Manchester City won to complete the Treble. PREMIER LEAGUE, FA CUP, CHAMPIONS LEAGUE

Give me a synonym for predictable mentioned in the passage. EXPECTED, FORESEEABLE

What word describes a player moving the ball with repeated feet touches while running? DRIBBLING

What is the capital of England? LONDON

Do you think it would be more challenging to coach a team or be a working part of the team? Why?

Would you find the continuous pressure of expectations motivating or stressful?

Would you rather defend a player whose move you know is coming but struggle to stop, or a completely unpredictable player? Why?



For years, one major stage was missing from Haaland's career: NORWAY had not reached a men's World Cup since 1998, two years before he was born. That finally changed in 2026, and Norway would reach the quarterfinals in Haaland's first World Cup, after a 2–1 knockout victory over five-time champion BRAZIL. The tournament also showed how far his popularity had traveled beyond Manchester and Norway; REUTERS reported that Norway jerseys became so difficult to find that new deliveries were disappearing from stores within minutes. England finally stopped his scoring run and eliminated (removed, knocked out) Norway 2–1 after extra time, but Haaland left his first World Cup with seven goals across five appearances. By September 2026, he had also reached an insane (ridiculous, wild) 59 Champions League goals in 59 appearances, already placing him seventh on the competition's all-time scoring list at only 26 years old. For somebody who does not follow football closely, Haaland is one of the easiest modern stars to enjoy: he is enormous, unexpectedly quick, occasionally goofy, and when the ball gets anywhere near the goal, there is a very good chance he is about to score.

Let's spell: FINALLY MODERN POPULARITY ELIMINATED

What had Norway not reached since 1998 until 2026? WORLD CUP

What five-time World Cup champion did Norway eliminate? BRAZIL

What organization reported that Norway jerseys were disappearing from stores? REUTERS

What stage did Norway reach in the 2026 World Cup? QUARTERFINALS

Which country eliminated Norway in the quarterfinals? ENGLAND

Give me a synonym for eliminated mentioned in the passage. REMOVED, KNOCKED OUT

Give me a synonym for insane mentioned in the passage. RIDICULOUS, WILD

Give one adjective we used to describe Haaland in the final sentence: ENORMOUS, QUICK, GOOFY

Brazil is located in which hemisphere: Northern or Southern? SOUTHERN

What color card acts as a warning to a soccer player for a foul or misconduct? YELLOW

What emotions might you experience being eliminated by the country you professionally play in?

Why do you think performing well at a World Cup can make a player more famous than performing well for a club?

Haaland's Norway jerseys became difficult to find during the tournament. Why do people like wearing the name or number of an athlete they admire?

Intentional Motor Activity: Norwegian Row

Using a cable machine, resistance band, or your imagination, begin seated (or standing tall if it's tricky to sit) with the arms extended and the shoulders relaxed. Pull the handle toward the lower ribs while drawing the elbows back, both arms at a time, then returning, extending slowly to the starting position with control. Focus on keeping the core engaged and steady rather than rocking backward to create momentum.

For motor planning, break the movement into a simple sequence:

REACH → PULL → SQUEEZE → EXTEND

You can cue each word one at a time, then gradually reduce the prompts as the movement becomes more automatic. For an added challenge, alternate between a standard two-arm row and a single-arm row, requiring the participant to adjust which side initiates the pull while maintaining the same controlled posture.

Primary focus: upper-back strength, shoulder control, bilateral coordination, sequencing, and controlled return.

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